BLENDING TRADITION WITH INNOVATION:

CCRAS's path to Global Ayurveda through human resource development

In the field of traditional medicine, the Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences (CCRAS) under the Ministry of AYUSH, under the visionary leadership of its Director General Prof. (Vaidya) Rabinarayan Acharya has embarked on several groundbreaking initiatives aimed at mainstreaming Ayurveda through evidence-based research and scientific validation. In this exclusive interview, Prof. Acharya sheds light on the strategic vision, key projects, and future aspirations of CCRAS for developing dedicated human resources for future research in Ayurveda. Join us as we delve into the inspiring journey of CCRAS and its pivotal role in advancing Ayurveda on both national and global platforms:



Prof. (Vaidya) Rabinarayan Acharya
Director General
Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences (CCRAS)

Prof. Acharya, under your leadership, CCRAS has launched several initiatives aimed at mainstreaming Ayurveda through scientific validation. The SPARK, PG-STAR, PDF, ARMS and PRAYATNA programs have garnered significant attention for their role in promoting research among students and scholars. How have these programs contributed to the development of scientific research in Ayurveda, and what are the future plans for these initiatives?

The SPARK (Studentship Program for Ayurveda Research Ken) and PG-STAR (Scheme for Training in Ayurveda Research for PG Scholars) programs play pivotal roles in nurturing the next generation of Ayurveda researchers. SPARK provides funding and support to undergraduate scholars, encouraging them to engage in research early in their academic careers. PG-STAR, supports postgraduate scholars in various domains, including clinical, pharmacological, and pharmaceutical research.

For advanced scholars, we offer the Ph.D. Fellowship Scheme, supporting Ph.D. candidates pursuing advanced research in Ayurveda. Additionally, our Postdoctoral Fellowship (PDF) program is tailored for promising fresh Ph.D. graduates of Ayurveda and other related scientific disciplines and postgraduate degree holders in Ayurveda with three years of research experience.

Our ARMS (Ayurveda Research Methodology and Research) program specifically supports first-year postgraduate students by providing them with the necessary resources, mentorship, and guidance to undertake meaningful research projects. Complementing this, the PRAYATNA initiative focuses on the dissemination of quality scientific articles by final-year postgraduate scholars, ensuring the broader communication and impact of their research. Moving forward, we plan to further expand these initiatives, increase the number of scholarships, and enhance the training modules to incorporate the latest research methodologies and technologies.

Could you elaborate on the strategic vision behind the Ayurveda Gyan Naipunya Initiative (AGNI) and its expected impact on the practice of Ayurveda?

The Ayurveda Gyan Naipunya Initiative (AGNI) was conceptualized to create a robust platform where Ayurveda practitioners can share their innovative practices and clinical experiences. Our strategic vision is to promote evidence-based practices among Ayurveda practitioners and ensure these practices are scientifically validated. The impact we foresee is a stronger, scientifically-backed Ayurveda that practitioners and patients worldwide can rely on for effective treatments.

The SMART 1.0 and 2.0 programs have been significant in promoting research among teaching professionals in Ayurveda colleges. Can you share how these programs have boosted scientific research in priority healthcare areas and the outcomes achieved so far?

The Scope for Mainstreaming Ayurveda Research in Teaching Professionals (SMART) program aims to enhance scientific research in priority healthcare areas through teachers in Ayurveda colleges. Out of 90 colleges that applied, 44 projects focusing on six disease conditions (12 on Osteoarthritis, 12 on Iron Deficiency Anemia, 8 on Psoriasis, and 3 each on Rheumatoid Arthritis, Generalized Anxiety Disorder, and Dyslipidemia) were selected. These projects are being conducted in 38 colleges, including 14 government institutions, based on criteria such as NAAC accreditation, NABH and NABL certification, patient footfall, and specific disease conditions.

Capacity building and training are crucial for advancing Ayurvedic research. Can you discuss the role of the Ayush Diksha and the HRD Cell in enhancing the skills and knowledge of researchers and practitioners in the field of Ayurveda?

Ayush Diksha is going to be our dedicated human resources development center, focused on training and skill development. It will serve as a comprehensive platform for year-round training and capacity-building programs for all stakeholders in Ayurveda, including students, physicians, teachers, researchers, paramedical, and administrative staff. Ayush Diksha offers a range of structured online and offline courses and programs tailored to meet the needs of each group. The establishment of the HRD Cell at CCRAS Headquarters further enhances these efforts by offering a devoted unit.

"With a clear strategic vision and a series of impactful initiatives, CCRAS is poised to achieve greater heights and make significant contributions to the health and well-being of people around the world.